SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #51 · WORK AND CALLING

“My work only matters to God if it's ministry.”

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Where it often comes from

Many believers hear more about missionaries and pastors than about plumbers, nurses, and clerks. Over time, a divide forms in the mind: spiritual work counts, ordinary work is just a paycheck. People in everyday jobs may feel their days are secondary, or even wasted.

What Scripture teaches

Paul writes, “Whatever you do, work at it with your whole being, for the Lord and not for men... It is the Lord Christ you are serving.” He also writes, “So whether you eat or drink or whatever you do, do it all to the glory of God.” God put man in the garden “to cultivate and keep it,” so work was part of creation before the fall. Solomon wrote, “Whatever you find to do with your hands, do it with all your might.” All honest work can be done for God.

> *“Whatever you do, work at it with your whole being, for the Lord and not for men, because you know that you will receive an inheritance from the Lord as your reward. It is the Lord Christ you are serving”* (Colossians 3:23–24).

Also see

> “So whether you eat or drink or whatever you do, do it all to the glory of God” (1 Corinthians 10:31).

> “Then the LORD God took the man and placed him in the Garden of Eden to cultivate and keep it” (Genesis 2:15).

> “Whatever you find to do with your hands, do it with all your might, for in Sheol, where you are going, there is no work or planning or knowledge or wisdom” (Ecclesiastes 9:10).

> “And to aspire to live quietly, to attend to your own matters, and to work with your own hands, as we instructed you. Then you will behave properly toward outsiders, without being dependent on anyone” (1 Thessalonians 4:11–12).

Common self-statements

- My job is just a paycheck.
- Only church work really counts.
- God does not care about my daily tasks.
- I am wasting my life in an ordinary job.
- Real servants of God are in ministry.
- My work is not spiritual.

Common logical errors

- Dichotomous thinking: Dividing work into sacred and secular.
- Discounting the positive: Dismissing the good my work does.
- Should statements: Insisting that I should be in ministry.
- Labeling: Calling my job “just a job.”

Challenging questions

- Where did I learn to rank work as sacred or ordinary?
- Whom does my work serve, and how?
- What does Colossians 3:23 say about who my real boss is?
- How can I bring honesty, kindness, and excellence to my job?
- What did Adam's work in the garden say about work?
- How would I treat my work if I believed God saw it?

Truth summary

> All honest work can be done for the Lord. My job matters to God because I matter to Him and because the work serves people. I can do my work as worship, with honesty, care, and excellence.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Occupation/Job/Work
- Servant
- Gifts, Spiritual
- Fruitful
- Witness

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Unemployment
- Thinking, Healthy

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Is He Worthy — Andrew Peterson
Honest recognition of a broken world can lead to hope in Christ's final restoration.

Voice of Truth — Casting Crowns
Test accusing or frightening messages against God's truth.

All Things New — Steven Curtis Chapman
God's renewing work offers hope beyond failure, decay, and loss.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "My work only matters to God if it's ministry"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"My work only matters to God if it's ministry." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who does my work serve?
- ☐ Who is my real boss?
- ☐ How can I work with excellence?
- ☐ Where did I learn to rank work?
- ☐ How can I show Christ at work?
- ☐ What is one task I can dedicate today?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I serve the Lord Christ in my work.
- ☐ Whatever I do can glorify God.
- ☐ Work began in the garden.
- ☐ Ordinary work is honorable.
- ☐ My work serves people.
- ☐ God sees my faithfulness.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Colossians 3:23–24
  "Whatever you do, work at it with your whole being, for the Lord and not for men, because you know that you will receive an inheritance from the Lord as your reward. It is the Lord Christ you are serving."
- ☐ 1 Corinthians 10:31
  "So whether you eat or drink or whatever you do, do it all to the glory of God."
- ☐ Genesis 2:15
  "Then the LORD God took the man and placed him in the Garden of Eden to cultivate and keep it."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Work as worship: Each day, note one task you did for the Lord and how.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.
  For example, Colossians 3:23–24 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I am serving the Lord Christ in my work.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Occupation/Job/Work" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- [ ] Name who your work serves. Write the people who benefit from what you do.
- [ ] Dedicate your day. Pray each morning, "Lord, this work is for You."
- [ ] Show Christ at work. Choose one act of kindness or honesty today.
- [ ] Memorize Colossians 3:23. Put it where you see it at work.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "My work only matters to God if it's ministry": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Work as worship
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~My work only matters to God if it's ministry.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, thank You for work. Help me see my daily tasks as service to You. Let me work with honesty, kindness, and care, and let the people I serve see Your love. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.